

Public Companies: Traditional Banking

Money center banks, investment banks, regionals, and custody banks -- kept distinct from your Fintech list

Context: Bank stocks are up but lagging the broader market in 2026 (KBW Bank Index +12% YTD vs. a stronger S&P 500), trading at roughly 12x earnings vs. 22x for the S&P -- a persistent value gap. Regional banks have outperformed money centers, with the KBW Regional Banking Index up ~19% YTD as capital rotated out of AI-driven tech names. Consensus expects 11% sector-wide earnings growth in 2026. Capital One's \$35B acquisition of Discover (closed April 2025) is the defining recent structural event, turning Capital One into a card network owner, not just an issuer.

1. Money Center / Global Systemically Important Banks

Company	Ticker	Role	Recent Signal (2026)
JPMorgan Chase	JPM	Largest US bank; the 'Quality Compounder' thesis -- market dominance and fee diversity	2026 NII guidance of just 2.6% growth to \$95B; stock has lagged the group despite bellwether status; \$105B non-interest expense guidance ran above market expectations
Bank of America	BAC	Second-largest US bank; the 'Rate/NIM Catch-Up' thesis	Trading at just 11x forward earnings; guided to 5-7% NII growth for 2026 (above JPM and peers), based on two assumed 2026 rate cuts; 79% of analysts rate it Buy with \$62 price target (~29% upside)
Citigroup	C	Global money center bank undergoing a multi-year turnaround	Best-performing money center stock in 2026 as confidence in its profitability turnaround builds; still trades around 1x tangible book value
Wells Fargo	WFC	Major US money center and consumer bank	Trailed the group in 2026 on margin contraction; fairly priced per Morningstar rather than a clear value opportunity

2. Investment Banks & Capital Markets

The 'Capital Markets thesis' -- direct exposure to the 2026 IPO and M&A; rebound rather than net interest income.

Company	Ticker	Role	Recent Signal (2026)
Goldman Sachs	GS	Leading global investment bank and capital markets franchise	Direct beneficiary of the 2026 IPO rebound (SpaceX, Klarna, Chime, and dozens more), M&A activity, and debt refinancing volume
Morgan Stanley	MS	Investment banking plus large wealth management franchise	Named alongside Goldman as a 2026 capital-markets-thesis pick, with added diversification from wealth management fee income

3. Regional & Super-Regional Banks

The strongest-performing bank sub-sector in 2026, benefiting from a deregulation package unlocking additional lending capacity.

Company	Ticker	Role	Recent Signal (2026)
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US Bancorp	USB	Large super-regional bank	Core super-regional name benefiting from the broader 2026 regional bank rally
PNC Financial Services	PNC	Large super-regional bank	Part of the regional cohort outperforming money centers in 2026
Truist Financial	TFC	Southeast-concentrated super-regional bank	Regional peer benefiting from improving loan growth and steady asset quality
Fifth Third Bancorp	FITB	Midwest-concentrated regional bank	Among the regional leaders, up more than 20% in 2026 on improving loan growth and asset quality
Citizens Financial Group	CFG	Northeast-concentrated regional bank	Named alongside Fifth Third as a 2026 regional bank leader, up more than 20%
Regions Financial	RF	Southeast-concentrated regional bank	Regional peer positioned to benefit from the 2026 deregulation-driven lending capacity unlock
M&T Bank	MTB	Northeast-concentrated regional bank	Regional peer within the broader super-regional cohort

Note: the KBW Regional Banking Index (KRE) is cited as the preferred vehicle for a 'reversion to the mean' trade on this sub-sector as a whole, if broad exposure is more useful than single-name selection.

4. Custody & Trust Banks

A distinct business model from lending banks -- fee-based, driven by assets under custody/administration rather than net interest margin.

Company	Ticker	Role	Recent Signal (2026)
State Street	STT	Global custody bank and asset servicer	Fee-income model gives it a different risk profile from lending-driven banks above, generally less rate-sensitive
Bank of New York Mellon	BK	Largest global custody bank	Core custody/administration exposure across institutional and asset-manager clients
Northern Trust	NTRS	Custody and wealth management for institutional and high-net-worth clients	Smaller, more concentrated custody/wealth peer to State Street and BNY

5. Card-Issuing Bank Holding Companies

These genuinely belong in both this list and your Fintech list -- regulated bank holding companies whose economics are driven as much by card/network economics as traditional lending.

Company	Ticker	Role	Recent Signal (2026)
Capital One Financial	COF	Major card issuer and bank holding company; now also owns the Discover payment network	Q1 2026 net income \$2.2B; "Discover integration continues to go well" per CEO; analysts expect ~4% 2026 earnings growth accelerating to ~21% in 2027 as merger synergies land; also acquired fintech Brex's card program in 2026

American Express	AXP	Closed-loop card network and issuing bank; see also Fintech list	Continues to benefit from affluent-consumer spending resilience, a structural advantage over mass-market card issuers
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Categories Worth Adding

- **Community Banks** — hundreds of smaller public community and savings banks exist below the super-regional tier; not covered individually here given the long tail, but relevant if you want full sector breadth.
- **Insurance-Adjacent Financials** — life and P&C insurers benefit from the same higher-rate/investment-income environment as banks and are sometimes analyzed alongside them; a distinct vertical not covered above.
- **Asset Managers** — BlackRock, Blackstone, and similar firms are financials but run fundamentally different (AUM-fee-based) business models from lending banks; already touched via BlackRock's ETF fee exposure in your Crypto list.

Generated July 10, 2026. This is a disjoint reference set, not a ranked or filtered list.